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Preliminary investigation update

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - Preliminary investigation update

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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Summary

On 18/06/2026, Saltbush Air SB512 was departing runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome when two kangaroos crossed the runway. The aircraft, a twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, was carrying 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. The crew rejected the take-off, and the aircraft came to rest 62 m into the runway end safety area. There were no serious injuries, although one cabin crew member reported bruising. The aircraft, however, was substantially damaged, and the aerodrome closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

The investigation is examining four main questions. The first is how the animals reached the runway, and the second is how the evening service was approved. The third is why no runway inspection was requested before departure, and the fourth concerns the rejected take-off and the stop that followed. Whether runway edge lighting affected the crew's view remains open.

In the meantime, the evening service has been suspended. A runway inspection is now required before every departure there after last light, and the aerodrome operator is repairing the perimeter fence.

What we know

Saltbush Air SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, was the last scheduled sector of the day from Tarlton Springs Aerodrome on 18/06/2026. It carried 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. The sector was the fifth of the crew's duty. It had been added that morning when the rostered crew reported unfit. The first officer was the pilot flying.

The aerodrome's only runway inspection that day was at 21:35 UTC on 17/06/2026 (07:35 local), before the first arrival. It recorded the movement area as clear. The aircraft's doors closed at 07:16 UTC, 40 minutes behind schedule, with the aerodrome in darkness. At 07:29:10 the tower cleared SB512 for take-off on runway 09, with the wind at 090 degrees and 6 kt. No runway inspection was offered or requested.

The take-off roll began at 07:30:02 with both engines at take-off power. At 07:30:29 the pilot in command called V1 (the speed above which the crew's procedure is to continue the take-off) at 112 kt. Two seconds later the first officer called two kangaroos crossing the runway from the northern side. At 07:30:32 the pilot in command took control and rejected the take-off at 118 kt, six knots above V1, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining. About one second later the aircraft struck the animals. The occurrence notification records that both animals were struck, while the pilot in command's account describes striking at least one. The No. 2 propeller and right main landing gear took the impact. Reverse thrust on the No. 2 engine was not available for the rest of the stop.

Maximum braking was established at 07:30:34, two seconds after the decision. The aircraft left the end of runway 09 at about 21 kt at 07:30:51. It stopped at 07:30:57, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area, upright and on the extended centreline. Beyond the prepared area the ground is ungraded. There was no fire.

At the pilot in command's request, the tower activated the aerodrome emergency plan at 07:32:10. No evacuation was commanded, and passengers left by the forward airstair. The occurrence notification records the disembarkation as 4 minutes 8 seconds after the aircraft stopped. Other sources place it between 07:34:40 and 07:38:48.

There were no serious injuries. One cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation. The aircraft was substantially damaged:

- three No. 2 propeller blades were damaged beyond limits
- the right main gear doors were distorted
- both right main tyres deflated through their fuse plugs
- the lower right fuselage was punctured

Two kangaroos were killed. The aerodrome closed for 4 hours 20 minutes. The operator's Head of Flying Operations has suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service.

What we are looking at

1. **How the animals reached the runway.** The investigation is examining the northern perimeter fence and the aerodrome's wildlife arrangements. Works register item WR-221 recorded the fence as failed in 04/2023, and its repair was deferred at three budget rounds. AS-139 10.4 does not require an aerodrome of this size to hold a documented wildlife plan. Both carcasses were recovered on the same side of the runway as an animal pad through the fence (Figure 1).



Figure 1: The northern perimeter fence at the 1,050 m mark, photographed on the site visit: the fallen section and the animal pad through it. Site inspection photograph SV-2026-0417-07, northern boundary at the 1,050 m runway marker, taken 23/06/2026

2. **How the evening service was approved.** CMR-2025-118 introduced the operator's first scheduled operation into Tarlton Springs after last light. It assessed the change as a schedule change only, and the daylight-only restriction in route risk assessment RRA-041 was not reopened. The approver has left the company and cannot be interviewed.

3. **Why no runway inspection was requested.** The operator's manual requires an inspection before the first departure after last light only at aerodromes listed in Appendix 8A. An aerodrome is listed only after a reported wildlife strike there. Tarlton Springs has never been listed, although its own sighting log records kangaroos on the sealed runway. The investigation is examining that criterion and why the log never reached operators.

4. **The rejected take-off and the stop.** The take-off was rejected six knots above V1. The investigation is examining the crew's rejected take-off training, which has presented only aircraft system failures. It is also examining the operator's procedure, which gives no guidance on a runway

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obstruction. A further question is how the timing of the reject and the loss of No. 2 reverse thrust combined against a scheduled stopping margin of 67 m.

5. **Runway edge lighting.** Whether edge light brightness affected the crew's view of the animals could not be resolved and remains open.

6. **Related matters.** Two cabin floor escape path lighting segments were found unlit after the occurrence, a fault the daily check cannot detect. Whether other aircraft are affected is being examined with the operator's engineering staff. The evening rotation's duty pattern is also under review, because this was the crew's fifth sector, 11 hours into their duty.

Containment and next steps

Four interim safety actions are recorded.

- **Evening service suspended.** On 19/06/2026 the Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service.
- **Night departure inspections.** On 26/06/2026 the operator issued temporary revision TR-2026-04 to its manual, which adds Tarlton Springs to the Appendix 8A list. Pilots in command must now request a runway inspection before every departure there after last light. The requirement applies until a permanent change is made, and the action is recorded as closed.
- **Perimeter fence.** The aerodrome operator installed a temporary electric wire on 25/06/2026. It has also funded works item WR-221 from its 2026 contingency and programmed the 140 m fence replacement for 09/2026, and this work is recorded as in progress.
- **Listing criterion.** The investigation has recommended that the operator list aerodromes on their wildlife exposure rather than on a reported strike. It has further recommended a route risk assessment trigger for any aerodrome the operator first serves after last light. A response was due by 30/09/2026, but the recommendation remains open.

No interim action has been recorded on rejected take-off training, on change approval, or on the cabin escape path lighting.

The next steps are still in progress. The operator's engineering staff are checking whether the same ballast is fitted across the type, and whether other aircraft are affected. The runway edge lighting question, however, cannot be closed with the evidence available. Nor is the report itself complete. The draft has yet to be read by someone outside the investigation, and the organisations and people it describes have not yet had the chance to correct matters of fact. The date for the fuller report is [NOT ESTABLISHED: expected date of the final report].

Distribution

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